



Swarm of security drones with surveillance camera flying in the sky

fastest growing drone markets in the world. The report highlights that the global drone market will grow from \$14 billion in 2018 to over \$43 billion in 2024. Approximately \$3 billion has been invested in drone companies worldwide and 2018 was a record year with \$702 million in disclosed global investments.

A report by Federation of India Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FICCI) notes that around 38 companies (2001 onwards) have applied for industrial licenses to manufacture UAVs (another name for drones) in India, and more than 50 start-ups have started providing services in the drone industry. If estimates by NITI Aayog are to be believed, the Indian market for UAV will be \$50 billion over the next 15 years.

Photography, as Ramasamy noted, is one of the top-most application areas in India where the maximum number of drones are being deployed. Not just weddings, drone photography has found its place in high-budget Bollywood movies and vlogging. The surveying industry, as per him, is still a dark horse when it comes to the usage of drones in India. He is of the view that as more and more data start coming out of drone usage, more applications will be discovered where these can be used. According to a report by Research and Market, India's commercial drone market is projected to grow at a CAGR of 12.4 per cent during 2020-2026.

The prime reason behind the increased adoption of drones is the availability of cheaper components that are used in manufacturing these. Tanuj Bhojwani from ispirit explains that components used in drones have become so cheap that almost anyone can create an amateur flying device today. Backing Ramasamy, Bhojwani thinks that India does have a potential of reaching up to ten million drone flights a day.

"The problem is not when a drone goes from point A to point B, but the problem is when ten million drones travel from point A to point B. They can crisscross each other and cause accidents. This is where the Digital Sky comes in. Digital Sky is designed to increase safe adoption and acceleration of drones in India," says Bhojwani. Digital Sky policy is designed

to encourage safe flying of drones in India. Bhojwani explains that even a small accident caused by drones can create wrong impression about the whole industry among people.

"India is in the process of developing standards for drone flying currently. A brilliant set of businesspeople, from countries like Abu Dhabi, Canada, and America, were able to convince authorities in their respective countries to allow them to use the column of aerospace which had become vacant. A few of these were also able to conduct successful unmanned air taxi runs," informs A.T. Kishore, CEO, Vidya Sangha Technologies.

He adds that something of similar nature has been taking shape in India since last few years. The government of India, as per Kishore, has been working on a scheme called Garuda. Encompassing the use of drones during Covid-19 and locust attacks, Kishore notes that Amber Duber, joint secretary, Ministry of Aviation, has been instrumental in getting that policy implemented on the ground.

Kishore also mentions the need of UAV pilots if India were to achieve the ten million drone-sortie mark. [The Aerospace Sector Skills Council of India has also recently launched a drone pilot training programme to facilitate and accelerate the number of drone pilots in the country.](#)

Covid-19: The game changer for drones

One thing that makes drones different from many other technologies existing out there is the fact that these have to be physically carried to the site of operation. Probably, due to

Top Five Opportunities in the Drone Ecosystem

1. There's a shortage of good drone pilots in India. Skilling people in flying drones is a big business opportunity.
2. Production of drones that can replace DJI is a big opportunity for drone manufacturing startups in India. The current anti-China sentiment is making the market of India-made drones bigger and better.
3. Drone services in the fields of agriculture, mapping, mining, and surveying, etc will increase multifold in the coming years.
4. The demand for software that can do data analytics from information gathered using drones is an opportunity for India to go global. Like software, India can be a leader in terms of designing the software part for different applications around drones.
5. Battery designing and manufacturing for drones is also going to be a big opportunity, especially when drones get approval for BLS operations as well as for carrying higher payloads.